one family has destroyed the dreams of three generations of Indians. I will ensure your dreams are fulfilled'; 'I can go back to selling tea if I don't become PM, what will Rahul do?'; 'My *choti behen* Smriti can give you the names of 100 villages of Amethi, the Gandhis won't be able to give the names of more than ten.' Never before had any politician dared to take on the Gandhis with such a frontal assault, that too in their family fortress. A BJP leader summed it up for me rather well. 'It was a bit like Sehwag hitting Shoaib for a six in Pakistan!''

The Modi onslaught forced Priyanka to react. She accused Modi of dragging her late father Rajiv Gandhi into the election battle and claimed the BJP leader was engaging in '*neech* rajniti' (low-level politics). It was an unfortunate expression to use, especially in a part of UP where the word 'neech' was a derogatory reference to the lower castes. Priyanka to be fair hadn't made the reference in caste terms, but it was enough for Modi to seize upon. Affirming his OBC status, Modi accused Priyanka of insulting his caste identity. This was typical Modi-style 'rajniti'—ingenious spin doctoring, seizing the words of the opponent to turn the tables on them and capture the political advantage in a flash. For Priyanka, it may have been a wake-up call.

Before leaving Amethi on the last day of the campaign, Priyanka thanked the journalists who had been chasing her for a fortnight for their support. Most of them had been swayed by her charm and candour. For one last time she was asked if she would take the political leap. She replied, 'I have to drop my son off to school.

Doon has strict rules. When you come from a family like mine that has seen personal loss, your priorities are different. Your family is everything.'

Perhaps, that one remark signifies the dilemma of the new generation of Nehru–Gandhis. For Motilal and Jawaharlal, the freedom movement was a magnet that pulled them away from the luxury of Anand Bhawan towards street agitations. Indira Gandhi learnt her politics by the side of her father, even if her style may have been dramatically different. Sonia, too, to some extent benefitted from constantly observing her mother-in-law.